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Reflections from Oceania on Indigenous Epistemology, the Ocean and Sustainability

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In the context of the Small Island Developing States (SIDs) in the Pacific island region, referred to here, as Oceania, the violence of the colonial experience is perpetuated to this day by widespread Christianity and education systems which marginalize indigenous knowledges and ways of being and doing. Dominant global development paradigms exacerbate this mindset relegating indigenous ways of knowing the world and being in it to the periphery of all discourse. Climate change brings to the fore the significance of indigenous knowledge systems which are inherently about sustainability and balance – living in harmony with the rhythms and cycles of the planet – our known cosmos. This paper explores the indigenous conceptions of custodianship and the role of the human within the known universe, in communion with land, sky and sea. It also presents the view that the arts; both heritage and contemporary are critical to meaningful discourse about sustainability.

Relationships are at the core of indigenous Pacific island worldviews. Despite the rich cultural diversity across and between the sub-regions of Micronesia, Melanesia and Polynesia, this is the one constant. At the core of what it means to be human is a shared life philosophy of balance, harmony and deep connectedness. Our epistemologies, our knowledge systems and practices are premised on relational spaces – hermeneutical dimensions of the life worth living. The ‘good life; is one that is grounded in core values such as love and compassion trust, respect, service, duty, responsibility and an important component of custodianship of the land, sky and sea. These we believe can never be truly ‘owned’ but rather are inherited from the ancestors and borrowed from the next generation. In the indigenous psyche, each generation are temporary custodians tasked with maintaining and nurturing human relationships within our known cosmos

Growing up in the Pacific islands, the ocean is a fact of life. One could say it is in our blood. Teresia Teaiwa is famously quoted for the line; “We sweat and cry salt water, so we know that the Ocean is really in our blood” (Hau’ofa 1998, p.392). Our epistemologies and lived cultural praxis reinforces a simple fact; we are the people of the sea and the ocean is in us (Hau’ofa, 1993). The reality of the 21st century however, is that many Pacific young people, have either lost or are at risk of losing that ancestral connection with the ocean. Our ability to read, connect and treat the Moana (Ocean) are now minimally understood and read through the use of modern instruments and western science. In this new mind-set, the ocean is viewed as separate from humanity and is treated as a resource to be exploited.

Culturally, Pacific peoples saw the ocean as an extension of the land. The ocean is a highway (Hau’ofa 1993; 2000; 2008) for navigation, a dwelling place of ancestral gods and as a mother who nurtures and replenishes. Within this epistemological understanding rests a deep respect for

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the Ocean. Everything is connected and Moana nui considered to be part of the land. In this frame, the ocean, the land fonua/vanua/fenua, the skies and everything within each are inter-connected comprising our notions of place and space – our known universe.

To speak of Tabu/Tapu, is to speak of Mana, as the two are mutually reinforcing. Where Mana may be loosely translated as “spirit” or “energy”, Tabu/Tapu is “sacred, spiritual and forbidden”. These encapsulate the dual notions of the sacred and the profane. The concept of tabu/tapu falls within the overarching concept of Vā (relational space). In this way, tabu/tapu is a tool, a means by which to achieve reciprocity (through mutual respect) in maintaining sacred relational spaces or Vā, between peoples, the ancestors, the natural environment and the wider cosmos (Tuwere, 2002; Tamasese 2007, 2009; Mahina 2011).

Conceptually, the tagata fenua/tangata fonua (man or human) is simply a part of the whole. Sacred places and spaces within the ocean and land are considered as having more mana for various reasons, most commonly believed to be the dwelling places of ancestors and/or ancestral gods and goddesses. When a Tapu/Tabu is placed on a specific area it prevents exploitation and protects both the lifeforms and energy in those spaces, as well as the wider community from the repercussions of behaving inappropriately in a sacred space. The coming of the new religion with Missionaries inevitably meant that all forms of spirituality and religious practices were rewritten. Mana and Tapu/Tabu were relocated to the vicinity of churches and thus removing the sanctity of natural spaces, thereby leaving the land and ocean open to human exploitation.

Tapu honors the sanctity of the spiritual, enforcing the rules or guiding parameters for respectful engagement within a specific relational space such as a Tabu/Tapu site – whether it be a graveyard, male-female relationship, or a marine protected conservation area. This spiritual dynamic cuts across both our natural and cultural heritage in our relationships with the Gods, the ancestors, the living, the dead, the environment and the cosmos.

When we talk about Mana and Tapu, we are referring to the act of negotiating what Samoans and Tongans refer to as the Va (relational spaces). Va Tapuia in Samoa and Veitapui in Tonga are sacred relational spaces. We believe that we are born into Va which already is and that each individual, family and community has a role to play in nurturing, maintaining and sustaining these sacred spaces and relationships. Ultimately, respecting the Va is about respecting the Tapu and honoring the Mana within a particular space. In Fiji, the notion of Sautu or peace and prosperity or harmonized existence is equally significant. It is inevitably the search for balance and harmony – or what the developed world now refers to as ‘sustainability’. We call it many things and in Samoa, Tonga and Fiji, this includes notions of Va, Tabu/Tapu, Mana and Sautu. We have lived it, breathed it and honored it for thousands of years. For instance, in Fiji, Vanua Sauvi “is similar to the Western concept of ‘no take zones’... it is derived from customary law to ensure the maintenance and sustainable use of resources for all the members of the community to share and enjoy for their survival” (Lagi 2017, p.191-2).

Our heritage arts give us an entry point into this conversation and are telling of these indigenous epistemologies and the Mana and Tabu/Tapu which plays out as we negotiate various relational spaces. In indigenous, place, space, time conceptualizations, the heritage arts are epistemological

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sites which contain cultural indigenous knowledge about life philosophies, history, spirituality, status, genealogies, and relationships. They are therefore critical references for teaching, learning and reinforcing of indigenous epistemologies (Koya Vaka’uta, 2013). Sadly, Colonialism, Christianity and western education systems have denigrated these sacred art forms, often referred to as Handicrafts. This derogatory treatment of sacred art practices attempt to subvert spiritual and culturally significant sustainability pedagogies.

A deeper investigation into heritage arts tell us about functionality of the art form – a beautiful, finely woven mat, an elaborately inked Tapa cloth, a finely carved war club inlaid with shell – all beautiful but functional. They tell us about spirituality and what it means to live in balance and they also tell us about gender specific roles – male-female relationships as well as gendered conversations and gendered knowledge and about social order. It is in the design, symbolism and ritual use of heritage arts that we learn about and reinforce relationships and how to respectfully develop, nurture and sustain these. They tell us about our aesthetics and spirituality and value-base - what we consider beautiful, good and correct represented in symmetrical, balanced, contrasted dark and light, etc. And they tell us about symbolism – how, through abstraction we capture entire narratives and sometimes multiple narratives which may be clan specific. These symbols which are found across a wide range of heritage arts act as a form of written language, as mnemonic devices which enable an oral peoples to capture their stories in earth, bark, root, blood, bone and ink (Koya Vaka’uta, 2013).

Contemporary arts however are distinct in that they are not spiritually significant. They are mostly produced using modern day tools, materials and/or processes and are likely to fall into the fine art, wearable arts, public art, expressive art, entertainment, interior design and or arts education and advocacy category. These art forms may contain references to cultural and natural heritage and indigenous world views about the deeper, human connection to place and space but they do not hold the same kind of cultural currency as heritage arts and are not considered cultural wealth.

What the contemporary arts do offer however, is an alternative platform for discourse in spaces where heritage arts are not recognized or valued. They provide an entry point for meaningful conversations about indigenous knowledge and the arts. Within the contemporary system of modern societies, it is the contemporary arts which helps create dialogic spaces for talanoa (informal conversations) and talanga (focused discussed) as well as talatalanoa (across space and time discussions or ongoing conversations/discourse over long periods of time. As such, it is the contemporary arts which play a critical role in the decolonization agenda as they offer opportunities for active and individual participation in social critique.

Sustainability conversations must begin from a deep understanding of the Mana/Tapu and Va/Sautu and, the arts can enable that dialogue. It will be essential that difficult conversations are facilitated within Pacific communities themselves, as well as with those who represent and perpetuate oppressive western systems of practice. Meyer (2017) provides a guiding caution:

Here is where we are heading. We are heading towards a collaborative future by understanding how best to think about the beauty and purpose of our past. Yes, our contexts have changed, but our hearts extend from truly beloved stock. Let us not get lost in nostalgia or lament what is no longer with us. There is purpose in our collective conflicts (p.134).

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Now more than ever the role of culturally appropriate and sensitive approaches to education and research (Thaman 2008; Koya Vaka’uta, 2017) development and spiritually are needed. If we are to reclaim and remember the sacred relationships required for sustainability – harmony and balance, we will individually and collectively need to take responsibility for a global decolonization movement. The arts provide an avenue for these new ways of thinking. They, like the ocean, are a highway that connects abstract ideas, values and beliefs with the tangible places and spaces of our times.

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